

IS MY ANGER DUE TO FEELING THREATENED?

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Decrease the frequency of occurrence of angry thoughts, feelings, and behaviors.
2. Think positively and realistically in anger-producing situations.
3. Come to see that anger is a secondary emotion, responding to fear or anxiety in response to a perceived threat.
4. Learn to self-monitor and shift into an introspective and cognitive problem-solving mode rather than an emotional, reactive mode when anger is triggered.
5. Shift from a self-image as a helpless or passive victim of angry impulses to one of mastery and ability to choose responses to feelings.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE PROBLEMS WITH ANGER

- Analyzing Acting-Out Behavior
- Anger as a Drug
- Correcting Distorted Thinking
- Identifying Conflict Themes
- Is My Anger Due to Unmet Expectations?
- Respect or Fear?
- Understanding My Defense Mechanisms
- What Do I Want for My Children?
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Dangerousness/Lethality
- Oppositional Defiant Behavior
- Posttraumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Is My Anger Due to Feeling Threatened?” activity is suited for clients who are capable of introspection and who have the desire to change reactive patterns of anger. It may be useful when clients describe perceptions of being unable to control their anger or have patterns of impulsive anger that are disproportionate to the triggering event or situation. Follow-up can include keeping a journal

documenting angry impulses and the client's use of this process to manage his/her reactions.

IS MY ANGER DUE TO FEELING THREATENED?

A wise person once said that every problem starts as a solution to another problem. In the case of a problem with anger, if we can see that anger is a failing solution to another problem, we can find an alternative that works better. Once we see this pattern, it's easier to let go of the anger.

What kind of problem would make anger look like a solution? To answer this we have to ask, when is anger useful? It's good for one thing: motivating us to fight. It's the fight part of the "fight or flight" instinct that is any creature's response to danger. When we feel angry, the chances are that we feel threatened and that our bodies want to fight against that threat, whatever it is.

This becomes complicated, because this mechanism developed in prehistoric people over thousands of generations, when nearly all the threats they faced were physical, such as wild animals or aggressive strangers. Some dangers are still physical today. More often, though, we face threats we can't defeat physically, such as not being able to pay all our bills, or chronic health problems. There are also threats to our self-images and our beliefs about the world, which can feel just as dangerous as threats to our careers or health. It can be threatening when people treat us as if we don't matter, if we base our self-esteem on what other people think of us. If we believe that life should be fair, an unfair situation is frightening and confusing and can threaten our faith.

In this exercise, you'll think about a situation that has triggered your anger, and try to identify both the threat or problem that the anger wants to fight and another solution that will work better.

1. First, think of a situation that has been an anger trigger for you—one that comes up repeatedly or has led to serious consequences because of your angry actions. Describe that situation.

2. Study the situation and identify the threat that triggered your anger. Was it a threat to your physical well-being, either your safety or your long-term health? Your financial or material security? Your emotional security (for example, a threat to an important relationship?) A threat of frustration, a threat to your self-esteem, or a challenge to your beliefs about the way the world works? It may be a combination of these things. Describe how this situation threatens you.

3. Think of a solution that will give you better results and cause fewer problems than anger, which may be your first reaction. Describe the solution and how it would feel to put it into action.

4. After you've thought about triggers and solutions, have your feelings of anger about the situation changed? Do you feel more in control?

5. Whenever you feel your anger building, if you can pause and ask yourself, "What's the threat, and what else can I do about it?" you can change your pattern and take more control of your feelings and actions. This is hard at first, but it gets easier with practice. In the beginning it helps to have reminders. Think of someone whom you trust to help you control your anger. Explain to that person what you are doing, and ask him/her to remind you to find the threat whenever you start getting angry. In return, you must commit yourself not to turn your anger against that person when he/she does this. Who is that person, and when will you talk with him/her about this?

Be sure to bring this handout back to your next therapy session, and be prepared to talk about your thoughts and feelings about the exercise.